

California. Households where, when you have extra money, you spend it because you don't know when you're going to get it again.

Initially, they did practical things with it. Justin paid off his undergrad student loans, bought himself a nice used car, and even paid off the remaining balance on his mom's vehicle. But after that, with no clear direction on what to do with that much money, the inevitable happened. It got spent.

Haley remembers vividly when the shift took place. She recalled, "We went to the Melting Pot with his siblings because they also received the same amount of money. And we dropped \$600 on dinner between all of us. At the Melting Pot."

They were dining out, taking vacations, and purchasing a new house with new furnishings to fill it. They weren't buying Lambos and Gucci, but they were experiencing lifestyle inflation on an accelerated timeline.

Less than four years later, not only was all \$600,000 gone, but they had racked up an additional \$220,000 of debt. They both enrolled in grad school at a private university, bought a timeshare, financed an SUV for their growing family, and started using credit cards because someone told them you needed credit card debt to have a good credit score. And instead of paying for everything, they thought the safe thing to do was to hold on to the cash and make low monthly payments on the big stuff. Except they didn't hold on to the cash.

In September 2019, the two teachers were finally on a salary system, making the most money they'd ever made and getting paid consistently on the first of every month. This particular month, they took a trip for their one-year anniversary, and by the time they returned on the 8th, they had no money left in their bank account. All their money for the whole month was already spent, and they had to rely on credit cards until their next payday. That was the moment they realized something had to change. But nothing changed—yet. A couple of weeks later, Haley went to Costco and came back with two-for-\$7 pumpkin muffins. A delicious treat that Justin should have thanked her for. Instead, it led to an argument that, at its core, was about not having an extra \$7 for muffins.

"That was the turning point," Haley said, "where we decided this isn't working. If we're making the most money we've ever made, relying on credit cards, and we don't have \$7 for muffins, this is a big problem, and we have to change it."